

"If conservation of natural resources goes wrong, nothing else will go right."

ROOTS OF CHANGE

In improving the quality, quantity and availability of food in the world, the evergreen revolutionary has always worked for sustainable development

■ By Amarnath K. Menon

He has his roots in the idyllic island village of Monkombu in the Kuttanad rice bowl of Kerala. But his distinction is his pioneering contribution as a plant geneticist mixing Mexican seeds with home grown varieties in Punjab in 1966 to develop high yield cross-bred wheat seeds—not rice—for bountiful harvests. In an era when cereals were in short supply, necessitating huge imports, Monkombu Sambasivan Swaminathan broke free of the shackles of a conventional agricultural scientist who is laboratory-bound except for occasional visits to demonstration plots. After the initial success with wheat, he did not rest on his laurels. His concerns widened to find out how farm researchers could cope with the emerging challenges to increase productivity, improve the

soil and moisture conditions, protect crops from pests, provide better nutrients and, most importantly, motivate those working in different institutes to deliver. Swamy, as contemporaries in the world of science call him, used his powers of persuasion to make agricultural research a romantic experience, attracting young minds to agricultural universities across the country.

To him, the gains in the laboratory have to be transferred into grains on the ground. His work at the International Rice Research Institute in Manila, Philippines, triggered a similar revolution in rice cultivation. It impressed Indira Gandhi enough to induct him into the Planning Commission. It is not just seeds but all

other inputs used by farmer that are superior to those used 50 years ago. Now he is working for greater food security that is threatened by climate change and loss of bio-diversity.

Swaminathan credits both his father and Mahatma Gandhi—whom he met in his childhood during India's Independence struggle—with inspiring him toward a life of public service. "Inspiration for a scientist like me comes from the realisation that my knowledge or my life can change the lives of many people," is how he describes the innate drive. "Agriculture is an achievement of really hardworking men and women, toiling in the sun and rain, to produce food for us. As scientists, we can only help them," he explains, as modest as always.

M.S. Swaminathan

Scientist 1925

HK RAJASHEKAR



Q: He is the first citizen of a developing country to hold which post?

A: The presidency of the Pugwash

Q: How many honorary doctorates does he have?

A: 46, from universities across the world

Q: When was he nominated to the Rajya Sabha?

A: In 2007 at the age of 82